LANDRY & SWARR
LOUISIANA'S ASBESTOS ATTORNEYS

5 Things Everyone Needs to Know About Second Hand Asbestos Exposure



Most people have at least heard of mesothelioma, a cancer that develops as a result of exposure to asbestos. Mesothelioma victims are often thought to be mostly older men (due to the delayed onset of the disease) that once worked someplace like a shipyard, chemical plant, construction site or facility where asbestos was used as insulation or as a part of the product being manufactured.

What is Second Hand Exposure?

Despite the general level of the public's familiarity with asbestos, many people are still unaware that exposure to asbestos often takes place in another form - a dangerous but often overlooked way of spreading asbestos fibers from one person to another.

This scenario is often referred to as "second hand" or "household" asbestos exposure, and unfortunately, it can have the same harmful consequences as first hand or direct exposure.

Given the serious risk to people who live with, or are around those who may have had direct exposure to asbestos, we would like to share the following important information:

#1:

You May Have Been Exposed Even Though You've Never Worked with Asbestos

People who are at the highest risk of exposure to asbestos include those that worked in shipyards, chemical plants and construction site. However, even if you have never personally worked with asbestos, you can be exposed.



According to the Environmental Protection Agency, this fire resistant mineral can be found in pipe coatings, the walls and floors around wood-burning stoves, roofing, siding, insulation, heat resistant fabrics and many other places. Not only could you unknowingly come into contact with asbestos, but you also risk exposure by coming into contact with someone else who has.

#2:

Asbestos Contaminates Clothing, Cars and Homes

Secondary or Household asbestos exposure occurs when a family member is exposed, or has been working with someone who was working with asbestos. The clothing this person is wearing, the car they ride in, and the entire house should then be considered contaminated. Anyone who rides in the car or comes into the house may then be exposed to asbestos.



#3:

Laundering Clothes for Someone Exposed with Asbestos Leads to Exposure

The reason that the person described above is so easily able to contaminate the car and the house is because their clothing has been contaminated with asbestos. This mineral is so dangerous to your health because it is made up of very small, jagged fibers.

These fibers can be inhaled, causing serious respiratory problems, and they can also easily get trapped in clothing. This is why anyone who handles the clothing of someone who has worked with asbestos, or worked with others who were working with asbestos, is at a high risk for exposure. As the clothes are handled, the fibers may become dislodged and become airborne. Once airborne, the person handling the clothes can breathe those fibers that were released.

#4:

Even Casual Exposure Can Be Harmful

Even if you don't live with someone who worked directly with asbestos, you are still potentially at risk to contract mesothelioma. And while we certainly do not mean to instill fear in anyone, the reality is that even those who come into casual contact with people who worked with or near asbestos have, in fact, developed cancer as a result.



To illustrate the point, here at Landry & Swarr we have seen more than our share of Louisiana cases involving hair care professionals suffering second hand mesothelioma. These people simply cut the hair of people who worked around asbestos.

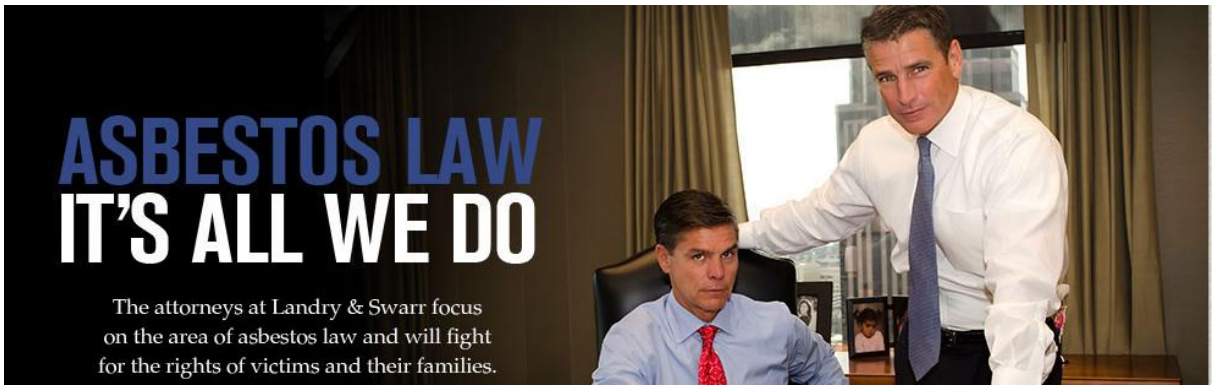
#5:

If You Have Concerns, Contact a Doctor as Soon as Possible



Secondhand exposure to asbestos must be treated just as seriously as firsthand exposure. In each instance, individuals are at risk for developing serious health conditions, including mesothelioma.

Asbestos, whether it develops into asbestosis, lung cancer or mesothelioma, can cause damage to the lungs and respiratory system. The best defense against these illnesses is to identify them and begin treatment as early as possible. If you believe that you have experienced first or second hand exposure to asbestos, it is never too early to see a medical doctor.



About Landry & Swarr

The attorneys at Landry & Swarr focus on asbestos law and will fight for the rights of victims and their families. We have extensive experience representing families dealing with all types of occupational diseases including malignant mesothelioma, lung cancer and diseases caused by other toxic chemicals such as benzene. Our firm prides itself on being skilled, tough litigators while remaining sensitive to the pain and needs of the families we represent.

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